you've no time to do anything about it. It just kills you. I saw it on the faces of the Bayern players the night United won in Barcelona. I have so much respect for them: they came back from that disappointment and won the trophy a couple of years later. To react the way they did shows the kind of strength of character the England players needed to find after Euro 2000.

It wasn't just the players who took criticism when we got back to England. The manager had to face a lot of it too, which at least took some of the pressure off Phil Neville. Given the way Kevin's teams, including England, play the game, I suppose it was bound to happen. It was the same when he was in charge at Newcastle: people love to watch his sides play but, when things don't workout, it's easy to say Kevin takes too many risks and doesn't put enough time into working on defending. I don't need to say again, though, how highly I think of him as a manager and as a man. The players knew, deep down, that what had happened in Belgium was our responsibility, however much anybody else wanted to point the finger at Kevin.

In international soccer, there's never time to go back to scratch and workout new ideas. As soon as one tournament finishes, you move on to try to qualify for the next one. In the autumn of 2000 we had our first games on the way to the 2002 World Cup. Of all teams, our first competitive fixture was against the Germans again, this time at Wembley. After we'd beaten them in Charleroi, many observers had said they were the worst German team ever; maybe they assumed that we'd just need to turn up to beat them a second time. So despite what had happened over the summer, expectations were right up there again. That October the day had an extra edge because it was the last game we were going to play at Wembley before the place got torn down.

There was so much build-up, so much looking back over the stadium's history, especially to the best afternoon of them all in 1966. Wembley was packed, of course, and when we went out to warm up you had the feeling everyone had come for a party, never mind a World Cup qualifier. Actually, the game was awful, as frustrating as any I've ever played in. Germany got an early goal when a free-kick from Dietmar Hamann skidded away from Dave Seaman and then they just sat there and bottled the game up; the field didn't help but we never really built up any momentum. They had lots of players packed in their own half and probably looked more likely to score another goal on a breakaway than we did to get an equalizer. I picked up an injury on my knee and I had to be substituted just before the end.

I went and sat on the bench, huddled up against the rain, and listened to the atmosphere around Wembley getting more and more sour. When the